

Culture as Democratic Infrastructure:

Participatory Practice and Culture as a Public Right

Field Reflection Paper

Culture is frequently discussed as a sector: a creative industry, a field of production, a domain of symbolic expression. Yet in practice, across participatory processes developed in Barcelona in collaboration with European partners, I have witnessed culture functioning less as an industry and more as a public right — and, crucially, as democratic infrastructure.

To speak of culture as a public right is not merely to defend access to artistic goods. It is to recognise that every individual possesses the capacity to produce meaning, to shape narratives, and to participate in the symbolic construction of society. When citizens are positioned primarily as consumers of culture rather than as producers of sense, something political is reduced.

Democracy does not depend solely on institutions. It depends on the existence of spaces where conflict, memory, difference and disagreement can be rehearsed without immediate institutional escalation. Cultural practice, when participatory and collective, can operate as one of those spaces.

Across numerous initiatives over the past years — of which I draw here on four as illustrative examples: Rassif, SMASH, MIRETAGE, and Beyond Gender — a recurring pattern became visible. In contexts marked by hostility, administrative rigidity, generational fracture, and migration-related precarity, culture functioned as a third space. Not outside society, but between polarised positions.

These four projects do not stand alone; they represent a broader body of work that consistently reinforces the same structural insight.

From Vulnerability to Authorship: [Rassif](#)

Rassif was developed in Barcelona with European partners and worked with young migrants — some minors, others recently of legal age — who had faced extreme conditions in their journeys to Europe.

The process culminated in a forum theatre piece built from participants' lived migration experiences. Rather than presenting fixed narratives, the performance staged dilemmas: bureaucratic barriers, institutional misunderstandings, social invisibility.

The audience was invited to intervene, step into the scene, and collectively test alternative responses. The theatre became rehearsal for negotiation.

In a public presentation at Blanquerna University, students of similar age encountered realities profoundly different from their own. The debate that followed was not abstract. It confronted questions of privilege, access, and structural protection.

What shifted was positioning. Young people frequently addressed by institutions as cases, files, or beneficiaries entered the stage as authors and analysts of their own trajectories. Culture did not eliminate precarity. It did not replace policy. It created a public environment in which those directly affected could produce meaning — and others could reconsider their own structural location.

Reframing Digital Presence: [SMASH](#)

SMASH (Journalistic Theatre against Online Hate Speech) was a two-year European cooperation project developed under the Erasmus+ framework. Among its components, one strand focused on participatory artistic workshops exploring digital polarisation with young people.

Within a 20-session process combining digital literacy and artistic creation, participants moved through two phases. The first analysed the architecture of online ecosystems — algorithmic amplification, comment escalation, performative outrage. The second shifted toward production: counter-memes, alternative narratives, embodied theatre explorations of digital hostility.

The intention was not to withdraw from social media, nor to moralise about online behaviour. It was to cultivate another way of inhabiting digital space.

Participants came to recognise themselves not merely as consumers of toxic discourse, but as agents capable of shaping symbolic environments. Theatre methodologies staged the escalation of conflict physically, making visible how hostility is structured and reproduced. Culture here functioned simultaneously as diagnostic and generative tool — exposing polarisation mechanisms while fostering creative intervention.

Memory as Bridge: [MIRETAGE](#)

MIRETAGE brought together members of three religious communities — Judaism, Protestantism, and Islam — to explore intangible religious heritage through participatory methodologies.

While three prototype heritage routes were co-designed, the most meaningful dimension of the process was not the routes themselves. It was the exchange of memory and ritual knowledge across traditions.

Through sensory exploration — objects, sounds, gestures, personal stories — participants shared practices rarely discussed outside their own communities. Instead of debating doctrine, they narrated lived experience.

In a context where religious identity is often filtered through political suspicion or media simplification, this encounter shifted the terrain. Memory became a language. Ritual became narrative. Difference remained, but proximity increased.

Culture did not attempt to reconcile theological divergence. It created a structured environment where recognition could precede judgement.

Structured Disagreement: [Beyond Gender](#)

Beyond Gender brought together older and younger women in a process that began within separate generational groups before converging.

The tensions were explicit. In early sessions, some older participants expressed the belief that contemporary social conflicts were the result of parental failure — that mothers had “raised them like that.” Younger participants reacted defensively.

The artistic methodology did not suppress these frictions. It held them within a shared creative frame. Through embodied exercises and collective creation, disagreement became articulated rather than explosive.

The objective was not harmony. It was navigability.

Culture here operated as civic rehearsal: a space where generational narratives could confront one another without immediate fragmentation.

A Broader Context

These processes unfold within a wider human landscape marked by deepening hostility and fragmentation — in Europe and beyond.

In different regions of the world, public discourse increasingly hardens into accusation. Migration is debated through fear. Gender becomes battlefield. Religious identity becomes shorthand for threat. Administrative systems grow rigid. Dialogue becomes scarce. In such contexts, culture is often reduced either to economic contribution or to symbolic consolation after political rupture has already occurred.

Yet there is another function.

Participatory cultural practice can create environments where individuals exercise their capacity to produce meaning collectively. Where disagreement is structured rather than silenced. Where memory is shared rather than weaponised.

Democracy does not weaken because conflict exists. It weakens when no spaces remain capable of holding conflict productively.

Culture as Infrastructure — and as Public Right

To frame culture as a public right is to affirm that individuals are not merely spectators within democratic life. They are co-authors.

Democratic systems require citizens capable of narrating experience, confronting difference, and intervening symbolically in shared space.

When culture is treated exclusively as commodity, its civic function narrows. When citizens are treated primarily as consumers, their participatory agency contracts.

If democracy requires environments where difference can be negotiated without immediate institutional escalation, then participatory cultural practice is not peripheral. It is part of its operating environment.

Nadia Onatibia